

"Seventy per cent of our country is young, the Youth Congress represents that part. For me that is the place to start." December 2010 is his deadline for completing elections to the youth wings. "We are at a transition stage, but a transformation is on within the transition itself," says Ashok Tanwar, president, Indian Youth Congress. He recalls how earlier senior leaders would 'recommend' appointments and promotions. Now, Rahul has replaced that culture of patronage and nomination. "The three Cs that were the trademark of the Youth Congress have been wiped out. That's the *chelas*, the *chamchas* and the *chap-loos* (hangers-on and sycophants)," chortles Jitin Prasada, a Union minister of state.

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WITH THE PRIME MINISTER AND WITH SONIA, BOTH PLAY MENTOR TO RAHUL



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RAHUL'S POLITICS IS A BLEND OF HIS GREAT grandfather's socialism and his father's policies of liberalisation. He is concerned about Bharat but not apologetic about India.

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What Rahul is doing is not just engaging with the young and the underprivileged but trying to give them a sense of empowerment. He has little patience for excuses as students of Don Bosco school in Guwahati found out. When they complained of lack of opportunities, he pointed out that unlike Uttar Pradesh, where most of the teachers themselves cannot speak English, most of the North-east was fluent in the language which helped them get good jobs in the services sector. Unlike other cowbelt politicians, he emphasises the importance of learning English. "I see in his eyes his father's unfinished agenda. He wants a modern India, but also one that would be more responsive to the poor," says Sam Pitroda, who has worked with both the father and the son, and is used to receiving e-mail queries from Rahul at 2 at night on issues ranging from telecom to education.

This next best Gandhian has adopted the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA) as the party's flagship

scheme. The SPG is used to his cavalcade braking suddenly in the fields of rural India as he spies a group of villagers sunning themselves, to ask them if they had heard of a scheme called NREGA. College graduates are educated about the RTI (Right to Information Act). Under Rahul's patronage, the NREGA and RTI have become the two most important acronyms in the lexicon of governance. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, too, is used to being petitioned by the young general secretary to increase the number of villages covered under the NREGA and letting Rahul walk away with a decision that had already been taken by his Cabinet. The relationship between Rahul and the prime minister works, with the younger leader refusing to entertain any suggestions by eager Congressmen for a mid-course correction at Race Course Road. Manmohan, for his part, says Rahul has far exceeded his expectations. He has even invited him to join the ministerial. But Rahul or RG, as he is known by his GenNext colleagues, has always refused, because that would be limiting his area of operations.